



Pokémon GO Tournament Handbook

ENGLISH VERSION

LAST REVISION: May 21, 2026



Contents

1	Introduction	4
1.1	Supporting Documentation	4
1.2	Competitor Responsibilities	4
2	Eligibility Requirements	4
2.1	Age of Eligibility	4
2.2	Pokémon GO Minimum Account Requirements	5
3	Team Construction	5
3.1	Battle Team Setup	5
3.1.1	Allowable Pokémon	5
3.1.2	Restrictions	7
3.2	Team Registration	7
3.2.1	Late List Submission	8
3.2.2	Team List Contents	8
3.2.3	Team Checks	9
4	Equipment Rules	10
4.1	Devices	10
4.1.1	Where Devices Are Provided	10
4.1.2	Where Devices Are Not Provided	10
4.1.3	Connectivity	11
4.1.4	Screen Recording	11
4.2	Game Area Management	11
4.2.1	Objects in Play Area	12
4.3	Headphone Use	12
4.4	Note Taking	12
5	Pokémon GO Tournament Styles	13
5.1	Double Elimination	13
5.1.1	Tournament Phases	13
5.1.2	Bracket Seeding	14
5.2	Swiss & Single Elimination	14
5.3	Round Robin	14
5.4	Online Competitions	14
6	Gameplay	15

6.1	Match Structure.....	15
6.2	Beginning the Game	16
6.3	Game Resolution.....	16
6.3.1	Concessions	16
6.4	Match Resolution	17
6.5	Game Information & Communication	17
6.5.1	Public Information.....	17
6.5.2	Inferred Information	17
6.5.3	Private Information.....	18
6.6	Effective Game Communication.....	18
6.7	Reviews Due to Technical Issues	19
6.7.1	Review Resolution.....	19
6.7.2	Reporting Reviews.....	19
6.7.3	Known Technical Issues	20
7	Rules Violations and Penalties	21
7.1	Penalties	21
7.2	Delivering Penalties	22
7.3	Reporting.....	22
8	Summary of Changes	23

1 Introduction

Welcome to the Play! Pokémon Pokémon GO Championship Series Tournament Handbook (Pokémon GO Tournament Handbook). This is not a guide on how to learn to play Pokémon GO. This handbook is specifically about game legalities, game management, tournament policies, and formats. By following the rules and guidelines in this handbook, you will be ready to compete at all levels of Pokémon GO competition.

This handbook is required reading for all Pokémon GO competitors and Pokémon GO Judges.

1.1 Supporting Documentation

It is the responsibility of all Judges and competitors to familiarize themselves with the [Play! Pokémon Tournament Rules Handbook](#) and [Play! Pokémon Standards of Conduct](#). Both these resources outline expectations and procedures for tournament play and behavior at Play! Pokémon competitions.

1.2 Competitor Responsibilities

It is the responsibility of all competitors to follow the information outlined in this document and any supporting documentation. This information is reviewed on a quarterly basis, so we encourage you to check back regularly for updates to the rules and guidelines outlined in this document and any supporting documentation.

Competitors are required to bring all the necessary implements to complete their matches. Depending on the level of play and location, requirements may change (such as having to bring a team list or providing one through an online client). Competitors are expected to follow posted instructions from the Tournament Organizers regarding the requirements of the tournaments in which they compete.

If you have any questions regarding expectations at a tournament, reach out to the Tournament Organizer as soon as possible for more information. If you experience any violations of our rules, or if a tournament is not being run to the standards outlined in this handbook and the supporting documentation, we encourage you to open a ticket with us through our customer support portal.

2 Eligibility Requirements

2.1 Age of Eligibility

The eligibility requirements detailed in the Play! Pokémon Tournament Handbook apply to Pokémon GO tournaments. However, competitors must also satisfy the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) age of digital consent in their home region to participate in Pokémon GO Championship Series events (any Pokémon GO events that award Championship Points).

The GDPR age of digital consent may vary by region but is never below the age of 13.

A competitor's home region is defined as the region or country in which they live, and their Pokémon Trainer Central account must accurately reflect this information.

Competitors who do not satisfy the GDPR age of digital consent in their home region may participate in Pokémon GO Championship Series events so long as they utilize a Niantic Kids account that is properly associated with a parent or guardian.

There are no age divisions in Pokémon GO Championship Series events. All competitors will compete in the same all-age division.

2.2 Pokémon GO Minimum Account Requirements

Competitors must ensure their account meets the below requirements to participate in Pokémon GO tournaments:

- Trainers must be at least Level 10 to unlock the Friend List and Battle Request features.
- Where an account is associated with a parent or guardian's Niantic Kids account, the Friend List and Battle Request features must be enabled via the Niantic Kids Parent Portal.

3 Team Construction

3.1 Battle Team Setup

A competitor's team may consist of up to six Pokémon, with a minimum of three Pokémon. This team, including move sets and Combat Power (CP), must remain unchanged for the duration of the tournament. A move set is defined as the specific Fast Attack and one or two Charge Attacks that a single Pokémon has learned for battle. It is a subset of the Pokémon's move pool, which is all the possible Fast Attack and Charge Attack combinations a Pokémon may learn in Pokémon GO. Competitors then choose any three of their total Pokémon to bring to each battle. The competitor may change this chosen combination of three Pokémon at the beginning of each new game.

Competitors must indicate which Pokémon are in their team by assigning each one a unique in-game label called a Tag or a unique nickname shared across each Pokémon in the Battle Team. None of the competitor's other Pokémon may have the same Tag or nickname.

Pokémon GO tournaments use Great League format battles. Pokémon must therefore meet the CP requirements for the Great League (1,500 CP or less) to be legal for play.

3.1.1 Allowable Pokémon

Most Pokémon available in-game are legal for play with a few exceptions. Prohibited Pokémon can be found on the [Banned Pokémon List](#).

The following Pokémon cannot be included on a competitor's team due to in-game restrictions:

- Ditto
- Shedinja
- Xerneas
- Yveltal

Changes to the legality of any Pokémon will be communicated through official channels in advance of any tournament. It is a competitor's responsibility to confirm the legality of their chosen Pokémon ahead of each tournament. The most up-to-date place to find legality updates and changes is the [Banned Pokémon List](#). Pokémon that are removed from the Banned Pokémon List are immediately eligible for use in tournament play.

3.1.1.1 New Releases

When new Pokémon and attacks are added to the game, they are not eligible for use in tournament play until 00:00 UTC on the Tuesday two weeks following their release. This means if a Pokémon is released on Tuesday, February 3, that Pokémon will not be eligible for use in tournament play until Tuesday, February 17, at 00:00 UTC. Similarly, if a new attack is released on Friday, February 6, it will also not be eligible for use in tournament play until Tuesday, February 17, at 00:00 UTC.

For Pokémon and attacks released at different times across multiple time zones, this eligibility cooldown period starts when the Pokémon or attack is released in the Pacific time zone (PT).

Below is a list of Pokémon and attacks that follow this eligibility guideline:

- Pokémon that are brand new to Pokémon GO
 - This includes Pokémon forms that have one or more of the following compared to existing forms:
 - different typing
 - different base stats
 - different move pool
- Pokémon that are newly eligible for the Great League (were not previously available at or below 1,500 CP)
- Pokémon that are newly made available as Shadow or Purified Pokémon
- attacks added to a Pokémon's move pool

A competitor may include newly released Pokémon or attacks on their team only if team registration closes after the newly released Pokémon or attacks become eligible.

In some cases, an existing attack may be updated or modified in the game before or during a tournament. In instances where an attack is updated and has already been present in a Pokémon's move pool for more than two weeks, that attack in its new state is available immediately for that Pokémon.

One exception to the above rules is the quarterly Seasonal attack updates that Niantic releases in March, June, September, and December. Those quarterly Seasonal attack updates will be immediately eligible for tournaments upon release. Any other exceptions to the above policy will be communicated through official channels in advance of any tournament.

3.1.1.2 Limited Metas

Some events may utilize a limited meta format, which will be announced in advance of the tournament. A limited meta will determine what Pokémon are available for competitive play with some restrictions and limitations. These limited meta formats can only be utilized for an event with explicit approval from The Pokémon Company International (TPCi). The [Banned Pokémon List](#) still applies to these formats.

3.1.2 Restrictions

The following additional restrictions apply to a competitor's team:

- A competitor's team cannot contain two Pokémon with the same National Pokédex number.
- A competitor may not use a Pokémon that is currently Mega Evolved or has Primal Reversion activated.
- A competitor's team may contain no more than one Pokémon benefitting from a Best Buddy CP boost.
 - Which Pokémon on the team benefits from the Best Buddy CP boost must remain unchanged throughout the tournament.
 - There is no limit to the number of Best Buddy ribbons that may appear in a competitor's team.

3.1.2.1 Nicknames & Customization

When customizing any aspect of their game, competitors must follow the [Trainer Username and Team Name Policy](#). In addition, the nicknames of Pokémon in a competitor's team cannot contain a Pokémon nicknamed with the name of another Pokémon—for example, a Raichu cannot be named "Pikachu."

Any competitor found to be in breach of the above policy during an event will be asked to modify the problematic aspect of their game and may be subject to Unsportsmanlike Conduct penalties.

3.1.2.2 Battle Team Authenticity

Taking any action that violates the Play! Pokémon or Niantic Terms of Service or using external devices, services, or programs to modify or create Pokémon in a competitor's Battle Team is expressly forbidden. Competitors found to have Pokémon that have been obtained by unscrupulous means may receive a Disqualification, regardless of whether the Pokémon originally belonged to that competitor or was traded to them from any source.

Anyone who believes they have discovered a new method of illegal team manipulation, via any means, should report this through the [customer support portal](#).

3.2 Team Registration

All Pokémon GO Championship Series competitions require that participants register the exact contents of the team they wish to use during the tournament. Competitors are required to provide a legible and accurate team list and team preview list of the Pokémon that comprise their team. The team list will serve as the source of truth when Organizers and Judges are reviewing the legality of a team, so competitors should take care to ensure the clarity

and accuracy of their team lists. Competitors are required to register their team for a given tournament by the advertised deadline.

Team lists should be completed in the language to which the competitor's Pokémon GO application is set unless otherwise specified.

Some team registration platforms may provide translation services, especially for events such as Regional and International Championships. However, this should not be assumed, and competitors are otherwise responsible for ensuring that they submit a team list in the correct language.

3.2.1 Late List Submission

It is at the Organizer's discretion whether to allow a competitor who registers late to play in the tournament. If a competitor fails to register a team by the announced deadline and the Organizer allows the competitor to play in the tournament, the Head Judge will review and accept the team list if it is a valid team. That competitor will receive losses for the first round of play.

Late list submissions should be accepted only if team list details have not been publicly published. Once an Organizer has published the team list contents publicly, no further submissions may be accepted. This is to protect tournament integrity.

3.2.2 Team List Contents

A full team list should include the competitor's name, birth year, and Player ID, alongside the following information for each Pokémon:

1. Pokémon species, including whether that Pokémon is one of the following:
 - a. A regional form (such as Galarian Rapidash)
 - b. A specific named form (such as Wash Rotom)
 - c. A Shadow, Purified, or currently boosted Best Buddy Pokémon
2. CP (for Best Buddy Pokémon, list the CP it will be used at)
3. All known attacks
4. HP
5. Nickname

Many large events will require team list submission through RK9 Labs' Team List Creator. In these cases, the competitor may fill out their team list in any language they wish, as translations are made automatically available to the staff team, though it is recommended they use the language to which the competitor's Pokémon GO application is set to minimize the risk of error. If team lists are submitted through a platform that does not provide automatic translation, they should be completed using the language to which the competitor's Pokémon GO application is set to allow for easy comparison to their in-game team by staff performing team checks.

Competitors may not deliberately obfuscate the contents of this list, such as by refusing to provide clarification when requested by an opponent or staff member.

3.2.2.1 Team Preview List Contents

A competitor's team preview list is a truncated version of the full team list. It should include this information:

1. Pokémon species, including whether that Pokémon is one of the following:
 - a. A regional form (such as Galarian Rapidash)
 - b. A specific named form (such as Wash Rotom)
 - c. A Shadow, Purified, or currently boosted Best Buddy Pokémon
2. CP (for Best Buddy Pokémon, list the CP it will be used at)
3. All known moves

The team preview list is considered an essential piece of equipment for tournament play. Failure to present this list to the opponent at the beginning of each round may result in Procedural Error penalties.

It is the responsibility of the Tournament Organizer to make it clear to competitors how team preview lists will be shared with their opponents. If the Organizer is providing the team preview lists to be shared—for example, by printing the lists submitted through a digital platform such as RK9 Labs—they must provide the lists in at least the local language in the location where the event is held. At International Championships, the lists must also be provided to competitors in English.

Some tournaments (particularly local events) may require competitors to bring their own paper copies of their team list. Such must be clearly communicated to competitors within a reasonable time frame before the event. In these cases, two copies of the list will be required: one team list and one team preview list. The version of the list provided to the opponent should be in the local language in the location where the event is held.

3.2.3 Team Checks

Team checks are required to be performed at all events that award Championship Points. Play! Pokémon expects that team checks will be performed on at least 10 percent of teams, but recommends that tournament staff strive to complete as many as is reasonable without loss of quality or disrupting tournament proceedings. The teams of all competitors advancing to the Top Cut phase of a tournament should be checked before those rounds begin.

Team checks may happen at any time during a tournament, from registration through the final round.

During a team check, tournament staff will check the following:

- Lists are complete and legible.
- Teams described are legal for tournament play.
- The Battle Team matches the team list submitted.
- If available, the contents of team lists accurately reflect what has been used for gameplay according to screen recordings from the previous matches.

4 Equipment Rules

4.1 Devices

Pokémon GO tournaments are played using mobile devices.

At a Judge's discretion, a match may be moved to a new station. Competitors must not move their match without receiving permission from a Judge. A match may only be moved between games and never while a game is in progress.

4.1.1 Where Devices Are Provided

Some tournaments require competitors to use devices provided onsite. This includes most Championship events, such as Regional and International Championships.

Competitors are not permitted to use their own personal device at such tournaments for tournament play.

The following guidelines apply at events where devices are provided:

- Provided devices are to be used for tournament play only. Personal use of provided devices is not permitted.
- Competitors should be prepared to log in to the provided device with their personal account. Competitors may refer to their personal device for authentication or security reasons while logging in. The personal device must be removed from the play area when this is complete.
- Competitors should log out from the provided device once each match is complete, taking care to remove any saved account information at that time.
- Competitors may not attempt to disconnect or remove any security element from a provided device at any time.

4.1.2 Where Devices Are Not Provided

Some tournaments require competitors to provide their own devices. Where this occurs, it should be clearly communicated to all competitors in advance.

The following rules apply at events where devices are not provided:

- Competitors are responsible for ensuring their device is fully functional.
- Competitors are responsible for keeping their device charged for the duration of the tournament.
- Competitors should ensure that devices and application clients with which they enter Play! Pokémon tournaments are unmodified—that is, free from both custom software and firmware.
- Competitors should ensure they have the latest game update downloaded prior to the start of the tournament, and that the latest software update has been performed on their device.

- Except in instances where there is a known issue in a more recent update that would impact competitive integrity.
- Airplane mode must be enabled while the device is connected to a tournament Wi-Fi network.

It is recommended that competitors bring a compatible power bank to tournaments where devices are not provided, as outlets may not be available onsite.

4.1.3 Connectivity

Various styles of game communication exists for Pokémon GO competitions. Any requirements or changes to how competitors are expected to connect to the internet during a tournament will be communicated as soon as possible to lower the potential disruption to the tournament flow.

4.1.3.1 Wi-Fi

Connecting to Wi-Fi is recommended for smaller tournaments (such as local League Cups and Challenges) where the risk of an unstable connection is smaller than in tournaments with a high number of competitors.

4.1.3.2 Hardwired Internet

At larger tournaments, competitors may be required to use a hardwired internet connection for their tournaments. As devices are provided at most Regional Championships and above, all wiring will be completed prior to the start of the tournament. Competitors are not allowed to unplug their device at any time during the competition.

4.1.4 Screen Recording

Screen recording is defined as the process of capturing what appears on your device screen. This captured footage will be saved as a file on the device and can be reviewed in case a competitor has a technical malfunction or other concern during gameplay.

Where devices are provided, competitors are required to record each match using the device's screen recording functionality. Competitors should not access, share, or modify recordings taken on a provided device. All screen recordings are retained until the end of the tournament. They are then erased from each provided device. Where devices are not provided, it is highly recommended that competitors have the ability to record the screen of their device. Without a screen recording, it is difficult for a competitor to provide evidence of a technical issue, which may lead to a Judge review being denied. Screen recordings should be played back only in the presence of a staff member regardless of whether a device has been provided or not.

4.2 Game Area Management

The Game Area is the space that competitors use during their match. It is each competitor's responsibility to keep the space clear and easily available for the match in progress.

4.2.1 Objects in Play Area

Competitors are permitted to have good luck charms or objects in the play space but must keep the play space neat. There must be no food or drink on the table.

At events where devices are provided, a competitor's personal mobile devices must be removed from the play area once that competitor has successfully logged in to the provided device.

4.3 Headphone Use

Headphones may be worn by competitors only if they are wired and plugged directly into the device. The headphone wire must be clearly visible. In the case where devices are provided, please contact a staff member to request the ability to use headphones with said device. A competitor should not unplug a provided device from the charging mechanism in order to connect headphones without express permission from staff. Headphones will not be provided.

When a wired network is used, competitors who wish to hear in-game audio will need to bring either USB-A headphones or an audio adapter that allows for USB-A input. When a wireless network is used, competitors who wish to hear in-game audio will need to bring either USB-C or Lightning headphones or an audio adaptor that allows for USB-C or Lightning input. Please check with your Tournament Organizer for clarification on device information.

4.4 Note Taking

Competitors are permitted to take written notes during a match and can refer to those notes at any time during that match, including during the team preview phase. While no prewritten or printed aids, including type charts, are permitted in the play space, competitors may take notes at any time during the team preview phase, which can be referenced at any point prior to the beginning of the next round. A competitor's note sheet must be completely free of text, handwritten or otherwise, at the start of each match.

Competitors may use a preconstructed outline for note taking, which must be blank at the start of a match and can be comprised only of lines and simple shapes (no words or symbols). Use of preconstructed outlines is up to the discretion of the Tournament Organizer, and competitors must follow any instruction regarding preconstructed outlines for note taking.

Competitors must be timely with their note taking and may not use a device that can send or receive messages as a note-taking device. A competitor may not refer to notes taken during previous rounds while the tournament is still in progress. Written notes taken during a match may not be given to other competitors during the tournament.

A Judge may ask to see a competitor's notes and request an explanation if needed. Because a Judge may ask to see a competitor's notes while a match is in progress, the use of codes, ciphers, abbreviations, or any other method of obscuring the meaning of the information is not permitted. Additionally, notes taken by a competitor

may not contain misinformation intended to deceive tournament staff. Should a Judge request clarification or a translation for notes written in a language not spoken by tournament staff, the competitor must oblige.

5 Pokémon GO Tournament Styles

5.1 Double Elimination

Pokémon GO events, such as Regional and International Championships, use the double-elimination format.

This format features two brackets, one each for undefeated competitors (Winners Bracket) and competitors who have lost one match (Losers Bracket). Competitors are eliminated from the tournament once they have lost two matches. Both brackets are played to completion. The champion of each bracket is then paired together in a Grand Final.

A competitor who reaches the Grand Final must receive their second loss of the tournament in the Grand Final in order to be eliminated from the tournament. Should the Winners Bracket champion defeat the Losers Bracket champion in the Grand Final, the Winners Bracket champion wins the tournament immediately.

However, should the Losers Bracket champion defeat the Winners Bracket champion, a “bracket reset” occurs, and play must continue until either competitor receives their second loss of the tournament. In this case, the competitor with a single loss wins the tournament.

A bracket reset is considered a separate match to the initial Grand Final match, and it is called a Grand Final Bracket Reset match.

5.1.1 Tournament Phases

Pokémon GO events with a large number of competitors may begin with a pools phase. In this case, the total number of participants are separated into “pools,” and competitors compete against each other within their pool. The top two competitors from each pool then progress to a final phase, where the winner of the tournament is determined.

The number of pools is determined as follows:

Number of Competitors	Number of Pools	Resulting Number of Final Phase Competitors
1–32	1	No final phase
33–64	2	4
65–128	4	8
129–256	8	16

257–512	16	32
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5.1.2 Bracket Seeding

Brackets may be seeded at the Organizer’s discretion with explicit approval from TPCi before it may be used in a tournament.

When applied, seeding is always determined according to quantitative performance data rather than any subjective criteria. The current methodology for seeding utilizes competitor performance data from the 2025 and 2026 Pokémon GO Championship Series seasons.

5.2 Swiss & Single Elimination

The purpose of this format is to run a number of Swiss rounds appropriate for the number of competitors in attendance, after which the top-ranked competitors are seeded into single-elimination brackets and play until only one competitor remains. That competitor is the winner of the tournament.

Some Pokémon GO events may use a variation of this tournament style.

The Play! Pokémon Tournament Rules Handbook illustrates which Championship Series events use which variant and the details and differences of each of those variants.

5.3 Round Robin

Round robin may be used at the discretion of the Organizer only when there are six or fewer competitors in the tournament for events at the level of Regional Championships and above.

During a round robin tournament, every competitor is paired against every other competitor until no pairings remain still to play.

5.4 Online Competitions

Pokémon GO Online Competitions may be hosted by The Pokémon Company International (TPCi). These competitions take place entirely within the game software and may follow a different tournament format from other Pokémon GO competitions.

Competitors may be required to link external accounts, such as a Pokémon GO account, to their Pokémon Trainer Central account to receive any associated participation rewards.

Competitors may use any tournament-legal device available to them for an online competition, but they can battle with only one account per competition. Competing with multiple accounts is considered multi-accounting. Competitors engaging in multi-accounting will be removed from the tournament and will not receive prizes for any ranking they achieved. Additional penalties may apply as outlined in the Play! Pokémon Penalty Guidelines, section 5.4.

Select GO Battle League Seasons called Leaderboard Challenges award Championship Points like live Pokémon GO Championship Series events do. They are limited to competitors within regions managed by TPCi. The format is a little different from in-person events, providing new challenges for competitors.

Competitors will participate in the GO Battle League, a global matching system that lets you battle with other Trainers around the world, to try to earn a ranking on the GO Battle League leaderboard. Top-finishing competitors at the end of a GBL Season can receive Championship Points for their performance.

The GO Battle League has a variety of formats and leagues in which Trainers can participate.

In order to earn Championship Points, Pokémon GO players need to have their Pokémon GO account linked to their Pokémon Trainer Central account with a Player ID attached, and they must have opted in to the Play! Pokémon program. Competitors who do not properly link their accounts by the time the GO Battle League Season concludes will not be eligible to receive Championship Points for their placement.

[Click here for more information on the GO Battle League.](#)

6 Gameplay

6.1 Match Structure

Once a competitor arrives at their assigned station, appropriate preparations should be made to begin play, such as logging in to the device, opening the Pokémon GO application, and determining which method will be used to initiate gameplay.

Before exchanging team preview lists, competitors should carefully review their list for accuracy. If they find any issues with their team preview list, a competitor should contact a Judge immediately.

When both competitors have arrived at their assigned stations, their preparations have been completed, and both competitors have received the battle request, competitors should exchange team preview lists. This begins the team preview phase. While competitors are permitted to view their opponent's team list at any point during battles, at the start of the match, and between each battle, the maximum time permitted for the team preview phase is two minutes. If either competitor does not understand their opponent's team list, they should call a Judge immediately.

Pokémon GO has a maximum battle length of 270 seconds (4 minutes and 30 seconds).

Between each game in a match, competitors will have the opportunity to select a set of three new Pokémon for battle if they so choose. The time between each battle should not exceed two minutes. If there are technical difficulties that occur between games, competitors should call a Judge.

Once the match is over, competitors should immediately report the score. For events using Challonge, competitors should call for a Judge to report the score. For events using TOM, competitors should accurately complete the match slip and turn it in to the Scorekeeper.

6.2 Beginning the Game

Once they are ready to begin, competitors must use one of the following methods to initiate play:

- One competitor may scan the QR Battle Code of their opponent. This feature is accessible from the Nearby Battle section of the Battle menu.
- Competitors may add one another to their Friends List so one competitor may issue a Battle Request to their opponent from their Friends List profile.

Competitors are permitted to use either method, and they may vary the method used to connect for each new game.

6.3 Game Resolution

Generally, a game concludes when a competitor knocks out their opponent's final Pokémon. On occasion, a game will conclude because the battle has reached the maximum time allowed by Pokémon GO (4 minutes and 30 seconds). An in-game graphic will inform competitors that time has expired.

A game may also end if one competitor chooses to exit the battle. In this case, the procedures in section 6.3.1 regarding concessions should be followed.

The winner should be clearly indicated by an in-game graphic at the end of each game. However, if this graphic is not viewable for any reason, the winner may be confirmed by viewing either competitor's in-game Journal. If neither competitor can agree on the result of a game and the result cannot be verified by viewing a competitor's Journal, this game will be considered void by a Judge, and a new game must be played.

If the Journal entry indicates a tie, the game will be considered void and a new game must be played.

6.3.1 Concessions

A competitor may decide to concede for any reason. A competitor who quits a battle before a winner is determined is electing to concede that game.

Competitors may not do any of the following:

- Resolve a game or match with an intentional draw.
- Ask their opponent to concede.
- Bribe, coerce, or otherwise pressure their opponent into any match result.
- Refer to tournament standings or wait for other matches in progress to resolve before deciding to concede.
- Decide the result of a match through random means (such as by coin flip) or through any other choosing method.
- Concede to avoid or override a penalty issued by tournament officials.

6.4 Match Resolution

Most matches at Pokémon GO events are best-of-three. The Winners Final, Losers Final, Grand Final, and Grand Final Bracket Reset in double-elimination tournaments are best-of-five.

Best-of-three matches conclude when one competitor wins or loses two games. Best-of-five matches conclude when one competitor wins or loses three games.

At events using the double-elimination tournament style, competitors should call over a Judge to report the final match results. Events using the Swiss + single-elimination tournament style should use match slips to report final match results. Once a match result has been recorded on a signed match slip or by reporting the results to a Judge, that result is considered final and cannot be changed.

6.5 Game Information & Communication

Information in a Pokémon GO game must be communicated clearly and understood by all competitors during a game. In tournament play, this is evaluated at three different levels: public, inferred, and private.

6.5.1 Public Information

Public information is game information that all competitors are allowed to know and should have unobstructed access to at any point during the match without it being tampered with or obscured by their opponent or the game. If a competitor requests public information as outlined below from their opponent and the opponent refuses to provide it, that competitor should call a Judge and explain the issue. Public information consists of but is not limited to the following:

- Team preview list contents
 - CP and Best Buddy status
 - Move set
 - Pokémon name, species, and form (including regional forms)
 - Whether it is a Shadow or Purified Pokémon
- Number of Protect Shields available and clarifying if they were used
- Number of Pokémon left
- Pokémon types

6.5.2 Inferred Information

Inferred information is any information that competitors are allowed to know but is not the responsibility of their opponent to provide. Typically, inferred information consists of but is not limited to the following:

- Health of a benched Pokémon
- Stat changes
- Form changes

- Move effectiveness
- Number of Fast Attacks used by a Pokémon during the course of a game

6.5.3 Private Information

Private information is any information that only the competitor themselves should know during the course of a game. If the information is not shown above as an example of public or inferred information, it is probably private information. This can include the following:

- Energy gained and current energy state
- HP stat
- Switch timer
- Information about a Pokémon not revealed during gameplay
 - This includes a situation where a competitor's back line is not fully revealed to their opponent.

6.6 Effective Game Communication

During the course of a game, competitors are expected to communicate effectively, in a manner that is both timely and sporting. They are to do so by way of the following:

- Communicating any game actions or changes to public information as they occur during a game. If competitors notice a mistake within any communicated public information, they are expected to call it out as soon as it is noticed.
 - Should this action result in a gameplay error, a Judge should be called immediately (see the Play! Pokémon Penalty Guidelines, section 5.5.3).
- Representing public and inferred information correctly.
 - Purposely miscommunicating to confuse an opponent can be considered unsporting behavior and a Procedural Error, which will result in a penalty (see the Play! Pokémon Penalty Guidelines, sections 5.1 and 5.3).
- Answering questions asked of them by a Judge about any information completely and honestly, regardless of the type of information requested. To protect inferred or private information, competitors may request to answer these questions away from their game.
 - Purposely stalling or misusing the ability to answer questions away from a game in progress can be considered a pace of play issue and gameplay error (see the Play! Pokémon Penalty Guidelines, section 5.5.3).

6.7 Reviews Due to Technical Issues

In some circumstances, a technical issue may occur during gameplay that disadvantages one competitor through no fault of their own. Competitors encountering such issues must initiate a review by a Judge in order for a rematch to be considered. Competitors may not determine the results of a review between themselves. A Judge must preside over all review rulings.

When a review is initiated, gameplay footage is examined by a Judge. The Judge will then identify the issue and determine any potential impact the issue had on the outcome of the game. Without a full-screen recording of the entire battle, Judges may not be able to make a reasonable determination regarding the impact of the technical issue on the outcome of the game. In this case, the results of the game will stand.

6.7.1 Review Resolution

Judges must use the knowledge and resources available to them to determine whether one competitor received an advantage or disadvantage as a result of technical issues. Should there be a significant impact on the outcome of the game, the game will be considered void, and a new game must be played.

Judges must clearly communicate any issues identified, and the advantage or disadvantage that resulted, to both competitors. Competitors may not refuse to abide by the ruling on a review. A review may be appealed to the Head Judge. The Head Judge's ruling on a review is final.

6.7.2 Reporting Reviews

Play! Pokémon tracks review history to monitor the state of the game and to determine if long-term action is necessary. It is therefore important that Judge reviews are reported whenever they occur.

A Tournament Review Summary Report should contain the following information:

- Tournament sanctioning ID (if applicable)
- Challonge link (if applicable)
- Player IDs and names of the relevant competitors
- Player IDs and names of any Judges who viewed the review
- A detailed account of the relevant proceedings of the event, the response from the Judges and Organizer, and the reaction, if any, of the involved competitors
- Recording of match in question (as a file or link if available)
- Outcome of the review

The Tournament Review Summary Report fully details all reviews requested during any one tournament.

To create a Tournament Review Summary Report, a .csv format spreadsheet file with the headers below should be created:

Tournament ID	Round of Issue	Judge Player ID	Requestor Player ID	Requestor Trainer Name	Opponent Player ID	Opponent Trainer Name	Issue Description	Result of Review	Appeal Judge (if any)	Appeal Result (if any)
XX-XX-XXXXXX	1	XXXXXX	XXXXXX	XXXXXX	XXXXXX	XXXXXX	XXXXXX	XXXXXX	XXXXXX	XXXXXX

A new row should then be completed for each review requested.

Review Reports must be submitted to playercoordinator@pokemon.com within seven days following the tournament's conclusion.

6.7.3 Known Technical Issues

Provided below is a list of known technical issues that have been observed to occur during gameplay. Known technical issues are subject to change based on the current version of the game software.

6.7.3.1 Minor Issues

Minor issues that generally do not impact the outcome of a game:

Final Battle Action Delay	The animations associated with the last action to be performed in battle are delayed, but the action occurs as normal.
Matchmaking Error But Game Starts	Competitors receive an error message while connecting, but the battle begins as normal.
Incorrect Visuals (Minor)	Some graphics are displayed incorrectly during battle. Downloading assets to the device may prevent this in future.
Protect Shield Issue	The Protect Shield animation displays incorrectly though no Protect Shield is used.
Game Synchronization Issues	One competitor appears to begin their turn later than the opponent despite inputs occurring at the same time.
Visual Lag	Some graphics are delayed during battle, though their associated actions occur as normal.

6.7.3.2 Major Issues

Major issues provide one competitor with an unfair advantage or disadvantage, and they usually impact the outcome of a game. Affected games are usually considered void.

Fast Attack Prevents Charged Attack	One competitor using a Charged Attack while their opponent uses a Fast Attack knocks out the competitor's Pokémon incorrectly.
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Forced Swap Missed Turn	A competitor's only remaining Pokémon experiences a delay when it is switched into battle. This issue presents in a number of ways, including damage delays, animation delays, or a temporary inability to select a Charged Attack.
Competitor Sees Battle Screen During Cancelled Game	A competitor who cancels a Battle Request by leaving the matchmaking screen may experience an incorrect visual of the battle arena, including the first of their opponent's chosen Pokémon. Potential for abuse exists due to the private information revealed. Judges should take extra care to determine that this particular issue is not intentionally induced by a competitor.
Incorrect Visuals (Major)	Some graphics are displayed incorrectly during battle. As a result, critical information is not available to one competitor. Downloading assets to the device may prevent this in future.
General Lag	A competitor experiences a delay between their input and the associated game action occurring. A "weak connection" notification may accompany this issue.
Application Failures and Freezes	On rare occasions, the application may fail, freeze, or quit unexpectedly.

Others issues outside of those described above may occur, and it is up to the discretion of the Judges to determine during a review if those issues impacted the outcome of a game.

7 Rules Violations and Penalties

Whether intentional or not, errors and infractions may be made during a tournament. While we may not be excited to give a penalty, it is everyone's responsibility to protect the integrity of each game, match, and tournament. It may be required that Judges or Tournament Organizers take corrective action regarding base infractions and their effects on a match's game state.

For detailed information regarding penalties, application, and deviations from standard penalties, please see the Play! Pokémon Penalty Guidelines.

Information present here is a brief overview, and information in the Penalty Guidelines supersedes the information in this handbook.

7.1 Penalties

Currently, Play! Pokémon utilizes the following penalties across our tournaments.

Caution: The most basic of assigned penalties. Cautions are verbal and not reported to Play! Pokémon.

Warning: A reported penalty that denotes a minor penalty. Similar to a Caution.

Game Loss: Applied when a mistake severely impacts the integrity of the game state. The game is recorded as a loss for the competitor receiving this penalty. In extreme cases where significant errors have been made by both competitors in a game, a Game Loss penalty may be issued to both competitors simultaneously.

Match Loss: More severe than a Game Loss, this penalty is applied when an action impacts the integrity of the entire match. The match immediately ends and is recorded as a loss for the offending competitor. In extreme cases where significant errors have been made by both competitors in a match, a Match Loss penalty may be issued to both competitors simultaneously.

Disqualification: The most severe penalty, applied when a competitor's actions significantly and negatively impact the integrity of the entire competition. The offending competitor's match ends immediately, they are removed from the competition standings, and they become ineligible to receive prizes. This can also result in removal from the premises.

7.2 Delivering Penalties

Whenever a penalty is assessed and delivered, that delivery should include the following:

- An explanation of how the competitor's actions are not allowed
- An explanation of the base infraction and severity of that infraction to the competitor
 - Cite the specific section or category for the base infraction
- An explanation of how the assessed penalty will impact the competitor's overall competition
- A reminder that the competitor may appeal this or any other penalty to the Head Judge

Judges should also treat information pertaining to penalties with sensitivity to prevent potential embarrassment to competitors involved. For this reason, and because Judges may lack complete information regarding penalties they were not involved in, Judges should refrain from commenting publicly on penalties in which they were not directly involved.

Should a Judge use a specific situation for training purposes, the issue should be sufficiently anonymized.

7.3 Reporting

Play! Pokémon tracks each competitor's penalty history to differentiate intentional repetition of infractions from unintentional occurrences and to determine if disciplinary action is necessary.

It is the Organizer's responsibility to provide Tournament Penalty Summaries to the Play! Pokémon program within seven (7) days of a competition's conclusion. An example can be found near the end of the Play! Pokémon Penalty Guidelines.

For any Disqualification, the Head Judge is responsible for providing a Disqualification Report. These reports must be provided to the Play! Pokémon program within seven (7) days of a competition's conclusion. Select "Disqualification Report" from the relevant drop-down menu in the Play! Pokémon customer support portal.

8 Summary of Changes

Date of previous issue: April 7, 2026

Date of current issue: May 21, 2026

1 Introduction		
Section	Page #	Change
1.1		Added links to policy documents.

2 Eligibility Requirements		
Section	Page #	Change

3 Team Construction		
Section	Page #	Change

4 Equipment Rules		
Section	Page #	Change
4.4		Updated language on note taking.

5 Tournament Styles		
Section	Page #	Change

6 Gameplay		
Section	Page #	Change
6.3.1		Bullet added for conceding to avoid or override penalties.
6.4		Added Grand Final Bracket Reset for clarity.
6.7.3		Updated stipulation for known technical issues.

7 Rules Violations and Penalties		
Section	Page #	Change